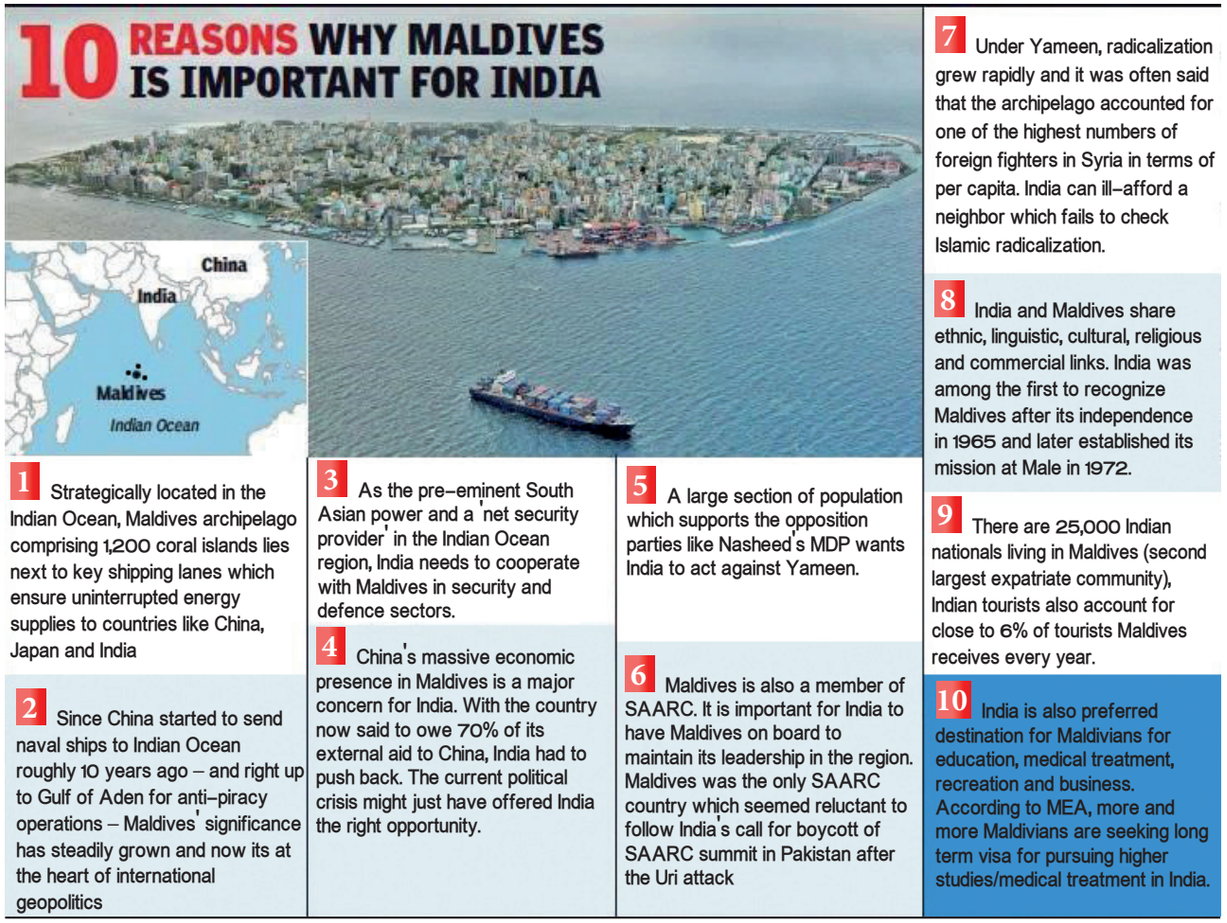



- **Indian Ocean Region hegemony:** Chinese heavy presence in Maldives would have given China an opportunity and a base to influence and control the Indian Ocean region. Also, the energy supplies coming from Gulf nations to India pass through this area.
- **Regional imbalance:** India enjoys unparalleled access and influence in many of the Indian Ocean island states, including the Maldives, Seychelles, and Mauritius which has been a problem for China. China-Maldives bonhomie can act as a counter to Indian influence in the region.

## Economic relations

- **Indian expatriates:** There are about 25,000 Indian expatriates in Maldives who are engaged in a number of professional pursuits and their security is also of prime concern for India.
- **Blue economy:** Maldives plays an integral role in realising the potential of Indian Ocean blue economy as a contributor to the security and sustainable development of sea resources.
- **Tourism:** India and Maldives see regular tourist visits between the two and Indian tourists also account for close to 6% of tourists Maldives receives each year.
- **Health:** India is a preferred destination for Maldives citizens seeking health services, which boosts Indian healthcare sector.

## Political relations

- **Political chaos:** Uncertainty in Maldives could prove a fertile breeding ground for extremism and religious fundamentalism, smuggling and drug trafficking.Islamic State (IS) and Lashkar-e-Taiba are also reported to have established bases in Maldives.



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